



Parent + Family College Support Guide

Help your student plan, ask better questions, and borrow with care.

MADE FOR

Parents, guardians, grandparents, and trusted supporters

Use this toolkit as a planning guide. Requirements, deadlines, and availability are set by each school, scholarship, agency, or provider. EFF cannot guarantee funding or outside assistance.

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Your role in the process

- Support organization without taking over the student's voice
- Create your own FSA ID when invited as a FAFSA contributor
- Discuss what the family can realistically contribute before choosing a school
- Protect the student's privacy; use secure school systems for documents

CONTRIBUTOR DOES NOT MEAN PAYER

Providing FAFSA information does not automatically make a parent responsible for college costs.

Family college meeting

- Compare net price, not sticker price
- Separate grants, work-study, student loans, and parent/private loans
- Review renewal rules and four-year cost estimates
- Set a monthly affordability limit before borrowing
- Name an emergency contact plan for balances, health, housing, and transportation

Our family's non-negotiables and questions

Before a Parent PLUS or private loan

- We know the interest rate, fees, repayment start date, and monthly payment
- We compared federal options and asked the school about additional aid
- The borrower can repay without relying on the student's future income
- We understand cosigner release, deferment, and default terms
- We are not using retirement funds or unsafe high-cost debt without qualified advice

Find additional family tools at portal.estherfundsfoundation.org/resources.